Short Suit Game Try

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A short suit game try may occur after an auction begins 1♥ : 2♥ or 1♠ : 2♠. When opener holds game-invitational values (15-17 points), bidding a new suit at the cheapest level shows a singleton or void. It asks responder to bid game without wasted values in that suit.

Short suit game tries must be alerted under World Bridge Federation (and many other) tournament rules.

Responses

Examples of responder's possible holdings in the short suit:

Suit Holding	Responder's action
xxx Jxxx Axxxx	Bid game
QJxx KJxx	Bid game with a maximum
KQJx AKxx AKJx	Sign off in 3♥/♠

Examples

Opener	Responder
♠KQT	♠53
♥AKT53	♥987
♦6	♦AKJT
♣K953	♣T876

Opener	Responder
1♥	2♥
3♦ (1)	3♥ (2)
Pass	

1. A SSGT in diamonds
2. Signing off with wasted diamond strength

Opener	Responder
♠KJ3	♠QT2
♥KQT632	♥J94
♦A32	♦KJT
♣5	♣7643

Opener	Responder
1♥	2♥
3♣ (1)	4♥ (2)
Pass	

1. A SSGT in clubs
2. Bidding game with strength in the other suits

Other Considerations

Giving extra information to the opponents

One disadvantage of short suit game tries is that they may indicate a safe opening lead for the opponents. Another danger is that the opponents may find a sacrifice. An opponent doubles with length and strength in the short suit, his partner finds himself holding 5 cards in the suit, and suddenly 5♣/♦ becomes an attractive obstruction.

Using hearts as the short suit

After 1♠ : 2♠, a 3♥ may or may not be a short suit game try. This requires partnership discussion:

Opener	Responder
♠AJT62	♠KQ8
♥AQ65	♥KT73
♦7	♦J65
♣A96	♣532

Opener	Responder
1♠	2♠
3♥ (1)	4♥ (2)
Pass	

1. Natural and forcing with 15+ points
2. Bidding the heart game with 4-card support

This sequence is natural because a 4-4 fit is often preferable to a 5-3 fit. These two hands play better with hearts as trumps, because the spades can be used to pitch club losers from dummy. Declarer can draw trumps in three rounds, run the spades, and then ruff a club in dummy for an overtrick. With spades as trumps, 10 tricks are the limit.

Note that this problem does not occur when the auction begins 1♥ : 2♥ and opener rebids 2♠. This is because responder should not be holding 4 spades and 3 hearts. With that distribution, he should initially reply 1♠, not 2♥. So there is no need for opener to look for a secondary 4-4 spade fit.

Lastly, the use of short suit game tries means that opener's 3♥/♠ rebids ask for help in the trump suit. In the following example, opener could make a 3♦ short-suit game try, but she isn't really interested heart or club support. Inquiring about responder's spades seems more useful.

Opener	Responder
♠T9876	♠AQ5
♥AK5	♥876
♦3	♦Q8764

♣AKJ3	♣42
Opener	Responder
1♠	2♠
3♠ (1)	4♠ (2)

1. Asking about trump quality
2. Good trumps

As an alternative to short suit game tries, see help suit game tries.

See also

- Help Suit Game Try
  The bid of a weak side suit as a major-suit game try.

